AI Impact on Student Life

2026 Cohort Analysis Report

> **Prepared:** April 17, 2026 **Sample:** 1,500 students · 5 AI tools · 6 majors
> **Source:** `AI_Impact_Student_Life_2026.csv`

Executive Summary

> **Conclusion.** AI adoption produced a small but measurable academic gain across the 2026 cohort: **59.6% of students improved their GPA**, with a mean uplift of **+0.088 points**. Differences between the five major AI tools are modest (≤0.01 GPA points spread), and student career confidence is largely independent of how intensively AI is used. The headline strategic concern is ethics: roughly **33.1% of students report High concern** about AI's role in academic work.

Key metrics at a glance

Metric	Value
Students analyzed	1,500
AI tools compared	5
Academic majors represented	6
Mean GPA improvement	+0.088
Improvement rate	59.6%
Decline rate	20.1%
Top-performing tool (GPA gain)	ChatGPT-4o (+0.094)
Top-performing tool (career confidence)	Perplexity (5.7/10)
High ethics concern	33.1% of cohort

Headline findings

1. **Academic uplift is real but modest.** Gains outnumber declines roughly 3.0-to-1, but the average improvement is on the order of one-tenth of a GPA point.
2. **No tool is a clear winner.** All five tools cluster within a 0.01-point band on mean GPA gain. Tool selection is not the dominant variable.
3. **Heavier usage ≠ better outcomes.** GPA gains do not increase monotonically with daily-usage frequency; intensity is not the lever.
4. **Career confidence is decoupled from usage.** Correlations between confidence and usage variables are near zero ($|r| \leq 0.03$).
5. **Ethics is the most actionable risk signal.** A near-even Low/Medium/High split, with 33.1% in High, indicates institutional guidance is overdue.

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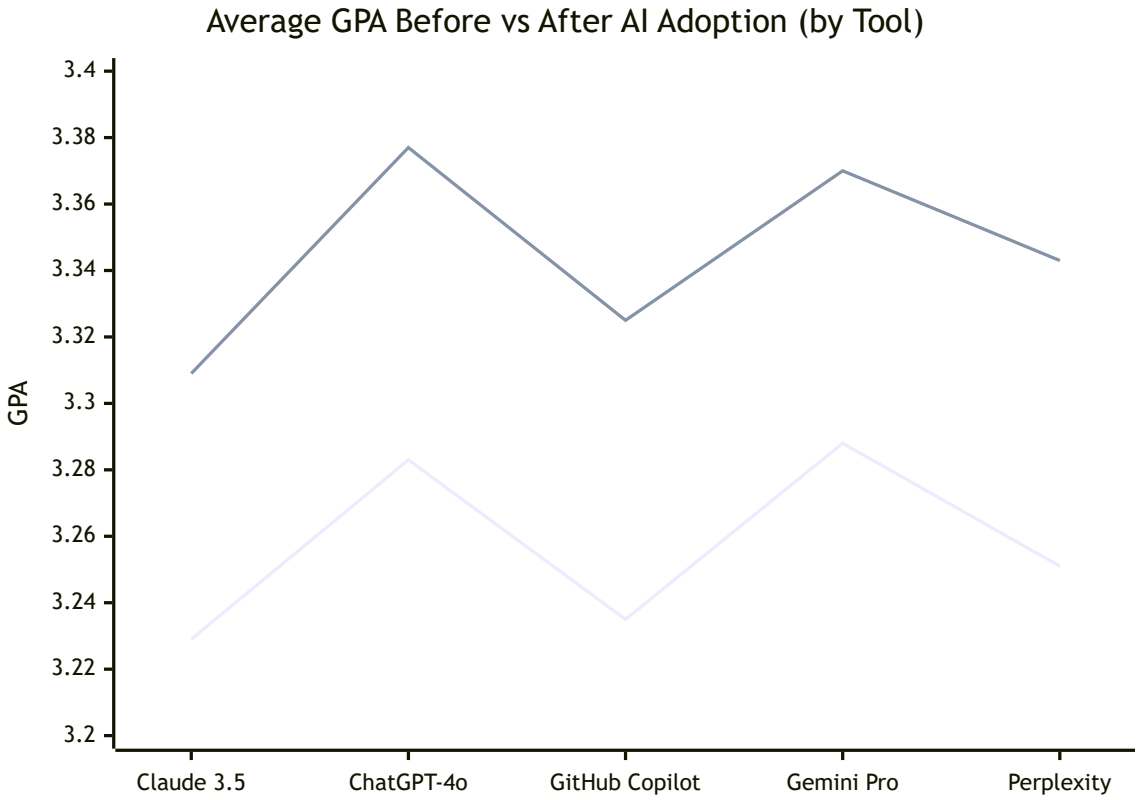
1. Academic Impact

> **Conclusion.** AI adoption shifts the cohort meaningfully, but unevenly. About **60% of students improve**, while the remaining ~40% split roughly evenly between unchanged (20%) and declined (20%).

Outcome	Students	Share of cohort
GPA improved	894	59.6%
GPA unchanged	305	20.3%
GPA declined	301	20.1%
Mean delta	—	**+0.088** (range -0.10 to +0.30)



Lower line: baseline GPA. Upper line: post-AI GPA.

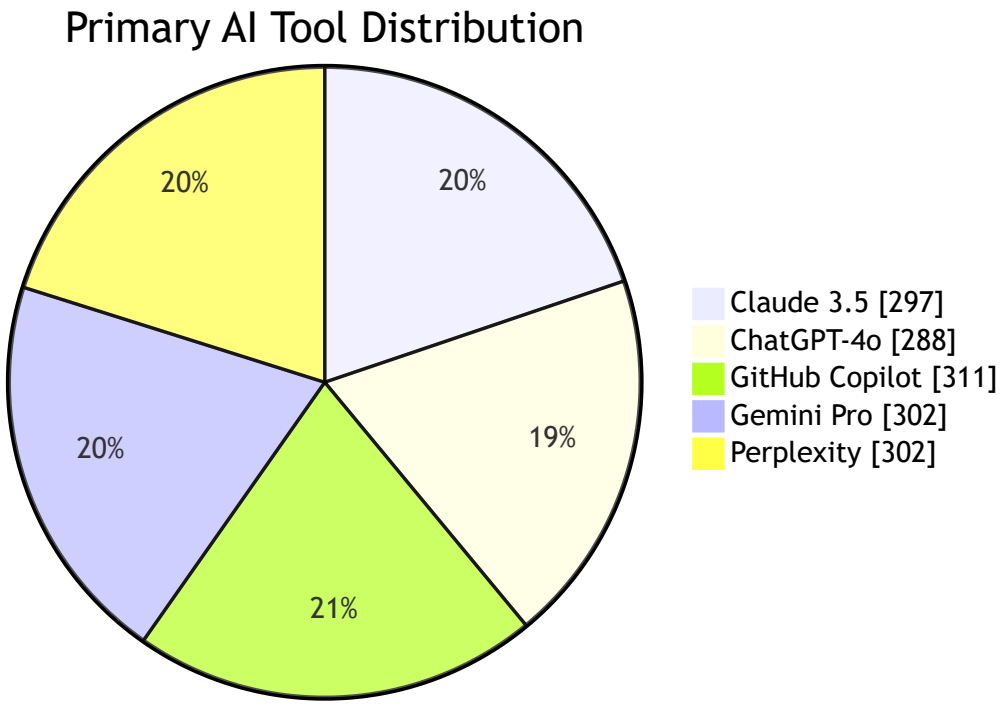
2. Tool Performance

> **Conclusion.** No tool dominates. The top-to-bottom spread on mean GPA gain is just 0.01 points across all five tools. Tool choice matters less than how the tool is used.

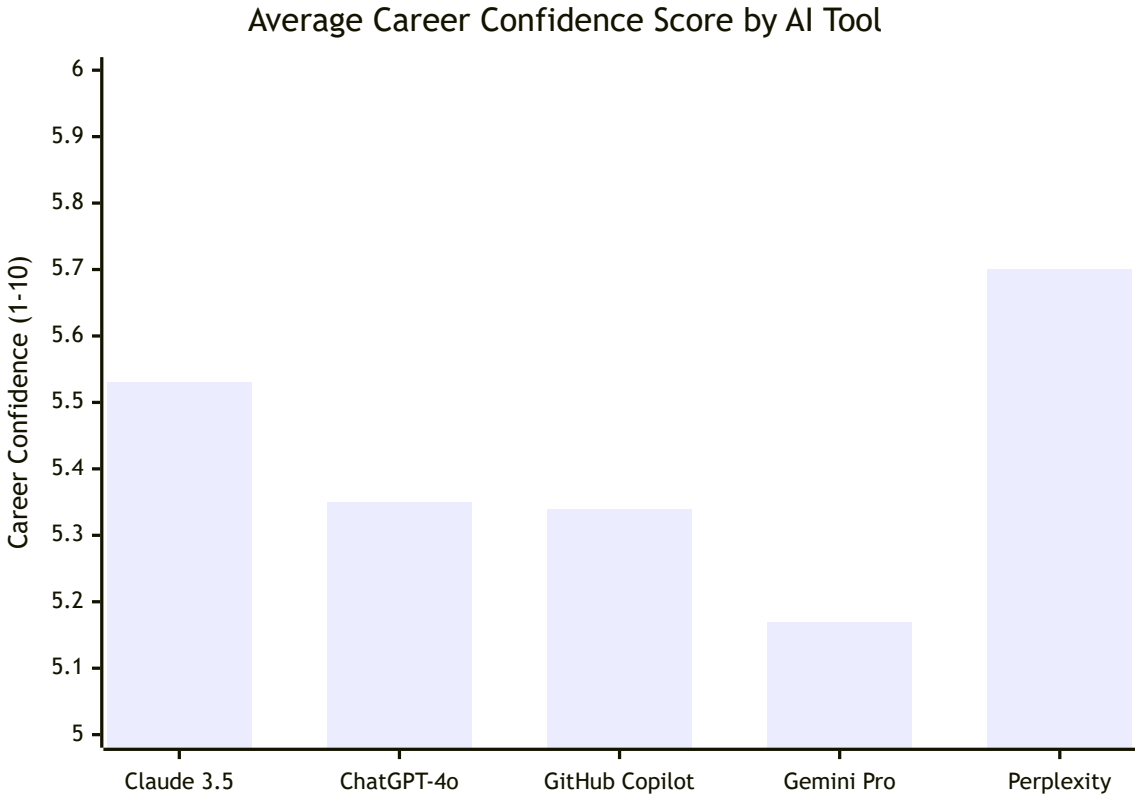
Tool	n	Mean baseline GPA	Mean post-AI GPA	Mean GPA delta	Mean career score	Mean hrs saved/wk
Claude 3.5	297	3.229	3.309	0.08	5.53	8.28
ChatGPT-4o	288	3.283	3.377	0.094	5.35	8.33
GitHub Copilot	311	3.235	3.325	0.091	5.34	8.44
Gemini Pro	302	3.288	3.37	0.082	5.17	8.64
Perplexity	302	3.251	3.343	0.092	5.7	8.85

Best for academic gain: ChatGPT-4o (+0.094). **Best for career confidence:** Perplexity (5.7/10).

Market share across the cohort



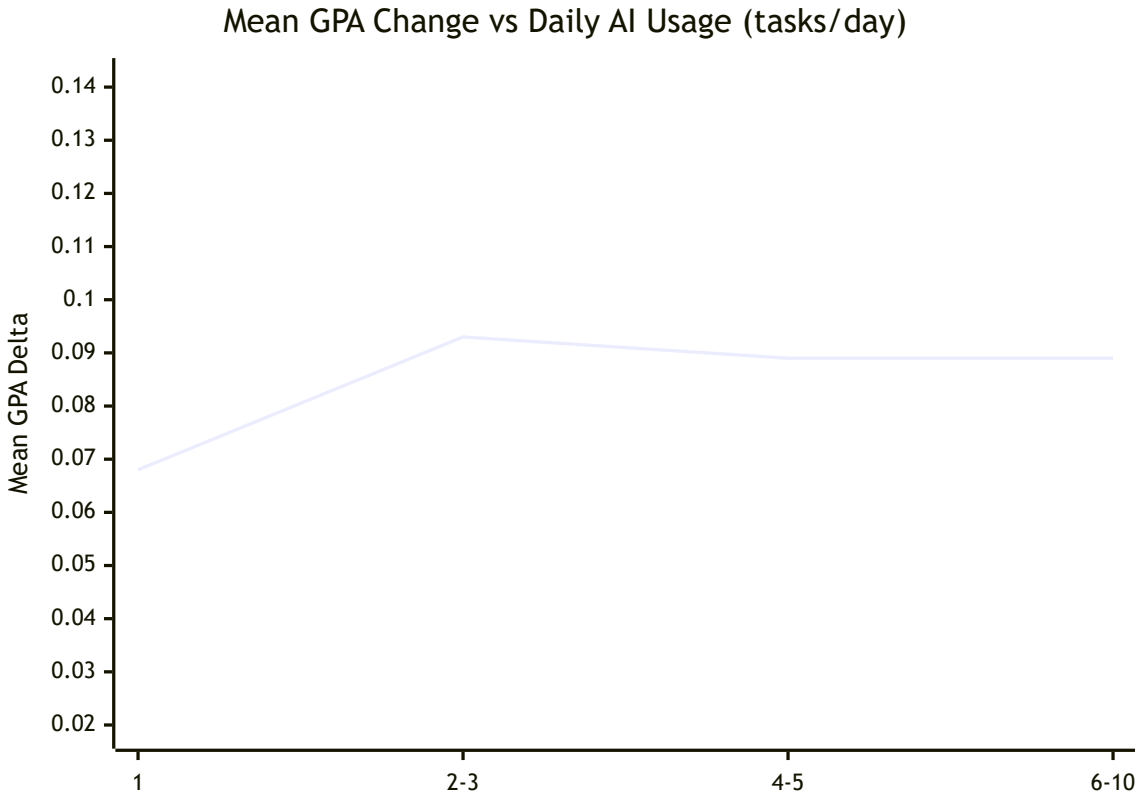
Career confidence by tool



3. Usage Intensity

> **Conclusion.** GPA gains do not scale with daily usage. The relationship across usage buckets rises only marginally — implying that *how* AI is used matters more than *how much*.

Daily usage bucket	n	Mean GPA delta	Mean career score
1	157	0.068	5.17
2-3	322	0.093	5.41
4-5	302	0.089	5.37
6-10	719	0.089	5.49



4. Career Confidence vs. AI Usage Patterns

> **Conclusion.** Career confidence is statistically independent of AI usage. Correlations with daily usage, time saved, and GPA change are all weak (|r| < 0.05). Confidence appears to be driven by factors outside the data captured here.

Correlations

Pair	Pearson r
Career_Confidence_Score vs Task_Frequency_Daily	0.025
Career_Confidence_Score vs Time_Saved_Hours_Weekly	0.002
Career_Confidence_Score vs GPA_Delta	0.009
Career_Confidence_Score vs GPA_Baseline	0.019

Mean career confidence by primary usage case

Usage case	n	Mean career score	Mean GPA delta
Brainstorming	286	5.26	0.088
Code Debugging	264	5.48	0.095
Essay Drafting	301	5.37	0.088
Exam Prep	341	5.62	0.083
Literature Review	308	5.34	0.087

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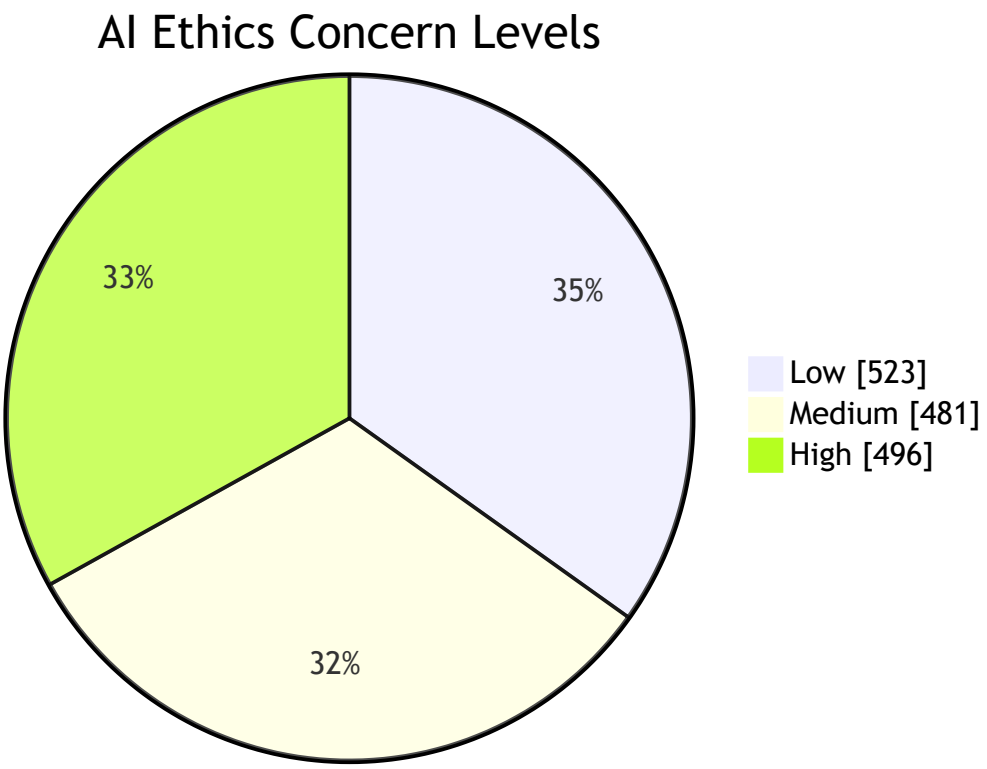
5. Ethics Sentiment

> **Conclusion.** Ethics concern is the clearest risk signal in the dataset. The Low/Medium/High split is near-even, meaning institutional posture cannot assume student comfort with AI.

Concern level	Students	Share of cohort
Low	523	34.9%
Medium	481	32.1%
High	496	33.1%



Concern distribution by tool

Tool	Low	Medium	High
Claude 3.5	110	99	88
ChatGPT-4o	96	94	98
GitHub Copilot	110	97	104
Gemini Pro	108	94	100
Perplexity	99	97	106

Strategic Recommendations

For educators and administrators

1. **Adopt a tool-agnostic policy.** With ≤0.01 GPA points separating the best and worst tools, mandating a specific platform is unjustified by the evidence. Focus governance on usage practices, not vendor selection.
2. **Make ethics guidance a first-class deliverable.** 33.1% of students hold High ethics concern. Publish clear, course-level guidance on permitted AI use; integrate academic-integrity discussion into syllabi.
3. **Invest in usage-quality coaching, not access expansion.** Heavier usage does not produce better outcomes. Resources are better spent teaching students *when* and *how* to apply AI than expanding seat licenses.
4. **Treat career confidence as a separate program.** Confidence does not correlate with AI usage in this data. Career outcomes need dedicated programming (mentorship, portfolio review, internships) — they will not arrive as a byproduct of AI adoption.

For students

1. **Treat AI as one of several tools.** 20.1% of students saw GPA decline after adopting AI. Adoption is not automatically beneficial; match the tool to the task.
2. **Quality of use beats hours of use.** Buckets of daily-usage frequency show no clean relationship with GPA gain. Reflective, targeted use outperforms heavy default use.
3. **Build career confidence deliberately.** Confidence will not rise simply because you use AI more. Pursue projects, internships, and mentorship in parallel.

Appendix

A1. Dataset summary

- **Shape:** 1,500 rows × 12 columns

- **Missing values:** 0
- **Columns:** `Student_ID`, `Age`, `Major`, `Primary_AI_Tool`, `Task_Frequency_Daily`, `Main_Usage_Case`, `GPA_Baseline`, `GPA_Post_AI`, `Time_Saved_Hours_Weekly`, `AI_Ethics_Concern`, `Career_Confidence_Score`, `GPA_Delta`

Per-column statistics

Column	min	max	mean	stdev
Age	18	25	21.494	2.297
Task_Frequency_Daily	1	10	5.407	2.904
GPA_Baseline	2.5	4.0	3.257	0.43
GPA_Post_AI	2.4	4.0	3.345	0.437
Time_Saved_Hours_Weekly	2	15	8.51	4.07
Career_Confidence_Score	1	10	5.417	2.844

A2. Career Confidence Score distribution

Score	Count
1	149
2	156
3	148
4	170
5	148
6	156
7	140
8	154
9	137
10	142

Cohort mean: **5.417/10** (stdev 2.844).

A3. Methodology

- GPA delta computed per student as `GPA_Post_AI - GPA_Baseline`, rounded to two decimals to remove floating-point artifacts.
- Daily-usage frequency bucketed as: 1, 2-3, 4-5, 6-10 tasks/day.
- Correlations reported as Pearson's r; values |r| < 0.10 are treated as practically zero.
- All percentages calculated against the full 1,500-student cohort.
- The dataset contains no explicit mental-well-being measure; the closest available signal (`Career_Confidence_Score`) is reported on its own terms in §4 rather than relabeled.